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Culture (OWC): [Amhara \(MP05\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: 1953-54, 1961

Coverage Date: Not Specified

Place Coverage: Ethiopia

Section Title(S)

5.2 Play and Entertainment • 5.2.1 Games and leisure-time activities

5.2 Play and Entertainment

5.2.1 Games and leisure-time activities

Games are differentiated largely on the basis of age: little boys' games are largely of a hazing type or of imitation of adult behavior; adolescents' games are predominantly competitive; adult games are largely leisure pastimes. In this adult-centered culture, children's games are at the same time freely experimental and directed toward growing up as fast as possible, while an adult would be ashamed to continue playing childish games or to compete with adolescents.

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Games

Small children, especially boys, are involved in hazing activities, b[unknown]dd[unknown]r, early in life. If they suffer a relapse into "bedwetting", they are publicly shamed by the older children, and made to urinate publicly into a little trench. Small children are sometimes frightened by older ones with the bullroarer, (z[unknown]zz[unknown]ta - onomatopoeic), or by imitation of the sound of the hyena at night. Frequency of contact between older and younger children is especially prevalent during the "shut-in" rainy season. At this time, boys aged five to twelve fight battles, sometimes using waterpistols (t'[unknown]kk'o[unknown]s from t[unknown]kkw[unknown]s[unknown], "to fire a gun") made of bamboo, with a wooden syringe. When the game gets rough they knock each other down with knees (the seat of strength in Amhara opinion) and feet ([unknown]ntu[unknown]s).

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Boys of eight or nine who aspire to deaconhood at the next New Year holy days are mock-examined by older boys who have achieved that status. The candidate must carry each of them several times around the churchyard, and must recite and chant liturgical prayers for them for hours. The candidate is

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punished for any disobedience by being pinched, tied up, and otherwise abused.

Little girls play milder games, such as dancing rounds with other girls, or two girls holding each other by the hand and spinning like a top. Sometimes somewhat older girls meet boys with whom they have established an experimental "joking relationship" (waza), and play house, building little huts out in the fields during the dry season, within the hamlet in the rainy season. This free experimentation comes to an end just before adolescence, when their relationships become more formal and more supervised.

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Childhood Activities

Imitations of parental activities fill much of children's playtime. Little boys play "farmer", weave rainhoods of reeds, and "broadcast" pebbles for seeds. Little boys begin to practice the "art of insult" (brain, not only brawn) e.g. such ethnocentric insults as the following:

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Question: "Where are you from?"

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Reply:	Response:
"Begemidir",	"Land of shysters and quibblers."
"Shewa",	"Land of liars and traitors."
"Gojjam",	"Land of sorcerers (buda)."
"Gonder",	"Gossipers and blabbermouths."
"Gurag[unknown]e",	"Land of tricksters."
"Tigrai",	"Land of hotheads."

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